The Acorn People

By Ron Jones

(Pg 1) Children spilled from cars and buses. The woods and paths of Camp Wiggin were accustomed to troops of running feet and the noise of children at play. With these wheelchair children there was only silence. It was as if the woods themselves were watching the unfolding of chairs and the lifting of bodies. All life seemed to stop. In procession, the parents wheeled their children toward awaiting counselors. I was a counselor. Like everyone around me, I didn't know what to say.

INTRODUCTION

Ron expected that his time as a counselor at Camp Wiggin would be filled with sunny days spent hiking, swimming, and boating. But when he arrives on day one, his illusions are quickly shattered. But everything changes once Ron gets to know his group -- kids who call themselves the Acorn People. The campers teach him that, inside, they are the same as any average kid, and with encouragement, determination, and friendship, nothing is impossible.

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(Pg 1-3) What do you say to a parade of children who move toward you only by the energy of their parents' insistence? Who move toward you with swollen heads of gargantuan proportion. With birth scars that have left the eyes without sight or the body without arms and legs. Children who seem drained of expression. Crumpled and stuffed into wheelchairs. Covered with blankets, to ward off not the cold, but the vision of disfigurement.

The camp nurse had given us a one-day orientation about handicapped children.

NURSE: Most will not live past their teen years. It is nature's way.

She described the hydrocephalic children with heads that looked like melons about to burst. And the disease of multiple sclerosis, which ate away at the muscles, leaving the body without energy or movement. The children who had mongoloid faces and a distant stare. And finally the children who entered life without vision or a hand or perhaps a face. *(beat)*

There were two counselors for each cabin of five children. I shared counseling duties with Dominic Cavelli from New York. He was after a career working with handicapped children. **(Pg 4)** [But it was] the thought of

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playing with kids, swimming all day, and taking long hikes had drawn me to this place. My illusions were quickly washed away. I wasn't about to frolic with these children. We would be lucky if we could even take a few steps together. *(beat)*

(Pg 9-10) The first of our kids was Benny. Polio had taken his legs but not his gall or heart. Most kids have a "thing" they do. Something special. For Benny it was speed. With a crash helmet pulled tightly over his head, he hunched forward in his wheelchair like a dirt-track driver in a stock car.

(Pg 10-11) Spider was another kid in our cabin. It was a funny name because Spider didn't have any legs or arms. He had stumps that stuck out from his short frame like broken branches out of a tree. Like Benny, Spider was alert and perceptive. You could tell by his eyes. Spider's eyes held everything. And what his eyes couldn't hold, his mouth tried to trap. Spider loved to talk.

(Pg 11-12) Far less active and alert than Benny or Spider was Thomas Stewart. He had muscular sclerosis, the cruelest ailment of all. Thomas must have been

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sixteen. It was hard to tell. Benny and Spider looked and acted like the eight- and ten-year-olds they were. But Thomas weighed about 35 pounds. Picking him up was like holding a collapsible tent. Thomas' mouth was always pinched tight, as if to hold in some final scream. He watched the world about him but gave nothing to it. Unwilling to move unless moved. Pensive, patient, and dying.

(Pg 12) Martin was the most able-bodied child in our group. Like other blind children in camp, he had a constant smile and seemed in perpetual motion. Sitting still, he would rock forward and back. Even standing, he swayed rhythmically. He was about fourteen, with bright red hair that stuck out in every direction.

(Pg 13) Aaron Gerwalski was the fifth kid under our charge. Aaron didn't have a bladder. A large, bag was attached to his intestines. Strapped to his leg, it collected urine that had to be emptied every hour. This condition was terrible for anyone, but for a teenager it must have been overwhelming. The smell repelled any gesture of friendship. It stalled and interrupted any conversation before it could begin. *(beat)*

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(Pg 14-15) Our first day we were assigned to the craft area. I rounded up Benny, got Martin to work with Spider and gave the quiet Thomas Stewart and Aaron each a private workspace. I busied myself with a nut necklace. An act of frustration that symbolized how I felt. Crazy to be here. Absolutely crazy. Spider asked what the necklace was for. . . "I feel a little weird being here, so I've made myself a necklace of nuts."

SPIDER: So do we. We're all a little nutty here!

BENNY: You might call us the nut people. Yeah, that's a good name for us.

SPIDER: Can we make a necklace like yours?

Benny raced about collecting every nut in sight. And soon we all had this crazy nut necklace in common.

SPIDER: **(Pg 16)** We're the Acorn People!

(Pg 22) And the Acorn People were on the move . . .

(Pg 25-26) The following day we [went] to the pool. [It] was being used by a group of girls! Participants in this first ever "integrated swim" were self-conscious and then flirtatious. The boys worried about their hair. My God, I had to comb their hair before they would venture out to poolside. [But] soon, the sun and water worked

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their magic. Children -- no, young adults -- no, **children** were playing games. Even Thomas Stewart, the most distant of all -- I caught him smiling for the first time when he oh so slightly nudged a girl. **(Pg 27-28)** There was a great deal of speculation as to who had a crush on whom.

There was a new excitement in the air. Leaving the pool area, I noticed that a blind girl named Mary was wearing an acorn necklace. The question of how she got the necklace slid from my mind until Aaron complained.

AARON: I've lost my necklace . . . hey, can we stop so I can make another?

BENNY: Couldn't be you gave it to Mary ... could it?

Aaron looked slightly sick and then relieved as Martin saved the day with an idea.

MARTIN: Let's make a bunch of necklaces, OK?

BENNY: Yeah, we can give them to our girlfriends.

We set about making acorn necklaces by the gross. By the end of the afternoon, there wasn't an acorn anywhere in sight. Not one. Throughout the days that followed they gave them to everyone. The entire camp -- kids, counselors, and even Mrs. Nelson, the nurse

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became Acorn Society members. **(Pg 29)** The giving of the necklaces drew the camp together and gave us all a feeling of confidence and a penchant for adventure. One particular adventure I shall never forget was the mountain. *(Beat)*

One evening the normal recorded taps and Boy Scout pledge were followed by an announcement that special merit badges would be awarded to all those completing the climb to Lookout Mountain.

BENNY: If the Boy Scouts can climb that mountain, can we?

(Pg 30) In the morning we made plans. Maps in the camp office gave the trail markings and location of the mountain. It was a six-mile hike round trip. We had no idea of the terrain. We took a bag of apples, some carrots, raisins and canteens of water. Dominic led the way pushing Spider. Next came Benny, wheeling himself, followed by Martin pushing Aaron. I took up the rear pushing Thomas Stewart. *(Beat)* Each curve in the trail presented an obstacle; **(Pg 31-32)** but when the trail started upward, we had to turn around and pull the chairs from behind. **(Pg 34)** Our movement was

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reduced to pull, stop. Pull, stop. Pull. Perspiring and heaving for breath, Benny had to stop. He didn't say a word. Just stopped pushing. His chair slowly slid to a halt against Martin. Like a train being derailed we twisted to a halt.

SPIDER: **(Pg 35)** *(dramatically sprinkling water from his canteen on the hillside)* I hereby name this place Benny's Landing and claim this place and all its riches for the Acorn Society. *(beat)* **(Pg 36)** Well, what are you waiting for, Aaron? Break out the food!

Here we were, sitting in the middle of a forest with wheelchairs that had until now known only city streets and "convenience ramps." *(Beat)*

(Pg 62-63) Later that night camp filled with the chorus of Cum Ba Yah. We were at peace with the world. And what a marvel -Thomas singing faintly for the first time.

THOMAS: *(singing)* Someone's singing, Lord, Cum Ba Ya

Why can't life be like this? Human beings in all their magnificence, working to find that moment of pride. The feeling of belonging not just to oneself but to the entire universe. *(Beat)*

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Camp days fled by. "How many days left?" was a constant question. The kids seemed to withdraw gradually but perceptibly into cocoons. Thomas stopped talking. Many children displayed symptoms of illness that marked their first few days at camp. Bedwetting returned. Kids on special diets who had been eating regular meals requested their pills again.

(Pg 78) [Then it was the final day of camp]. Now a silent exchange was taking place again. Children were being passed from counselor back to parent. Benny rolled slowly by himself from our presence. Spider was passed from arm to arm. Martin walked holding my hand. He was leading. Thomas Stewart had to be carried. His eyes were a little older and sadder. Aaron wanted to push himself to show his parents his strength.

[These were] the members of the Acorn Society -- -- racers, [swimmers], mountain climbers, observers, [and above all children] And they were dying.

NURSE: **(Pg 2)** Most will not live past their teen years. It is nature's way. *(long beat)*

(Pg 80) Thomas and Aaron died one year after

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summer camp. Spider was killed by a car the following year. Martin died in a car accident four years later. Benny was the last child to leave this [world]. Of all the children he was the only one to have a funeral. At the final service Benny's mother gave me a white envelope. Inside was a crumpled acorn necklace. She said he gave them to everyone he met. *(beat)*

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